AEP FROM ZERO • PART 2 • SPEAK TO YOUR CUSTOMER (AJO)

EPISODE 18

AJO Test Mode vs Simulation vs Dry Run vs Proof

How do you test a journey in Adobe Journey Optimizer (AJO) without emailing real customers? This AJO tutorial compares Test mode, Simulation, Dry run and Send proof: which ones send real email, what each one is best for, and their limits, including why Test mode takes the top branch of a split. You will learn how to create and load AJO test profiles safely with the testProfile flag, prove every path of a journey with Dry run, preview content with Simulate content, and catch a broken 'Hi ,' greeting with a

Previously: a perfect canvas, still Draft

- Last time: Bloom Welcome v1 built, status Draft
- Entry, Optimize on Gold Members, two welcome emails
- A 2-day wait on each path, then End
- Zero errors, one opt-out warning
- Today: run people through it safely
- The catch: some test buttons send real email

KEY IDEA

Bloom Welcome v1 is built with zero errors. Today the team runs people through it, without one email reaching a real customer.

Divya's rule: looking is safe, sending is not

Option	Reaches a real inbox?	Who goes through
Alerts panel	Never	Nobody: it only checks
Dry run	Never	Real profiles, counted only
Test mode	Yes	Stored test profiles
Simulation	Yes	Simulated users you create
Send proof	Yes	Up to 10 typed addresses

KEY IDEA

Several test buttons send real email through the real pipeline. Alerts and Dry run contact nobody; Test mode, Simulation and Send proof can.

The four test seats, each with its own inbox

Seat	State	Built to prove
TD-KAVYA-01	Gold	Gold content
TD-FARHAN-02	Silver, recent buyer	What everyone else sees
TD-DIVYA-03	Lapsed, email consent true	The win-back path, later
TD-ROHAN-04	Silver, first name empty	That test profiles lie

KEY IDEA

A test profile carries testProfile set to true. Bloom's four seats have IDs starting TD, and each carries only its owner's inbox.

How to create and load test profiles safely

- IDs start with TD; testProfile set to true
- Only your own inbox on the profile
- Load into your own dataset, never a shared one
- Profile toggle on before you upload
- Never reuse a real customer's ID
- Update profile activity: not for practice

KEY IDEA

Flag it as a test profile, load it into your own dataset with Profile switched on first, never reuse a real customer's ID, and use only your own inbox.

Does Test mode send real emails?

- Real emails to the inboxes on test profiles
- Only test profiles enter, up to 100
- The journey is locked for editing
- Every wait shortened to 10 seconds
- On a split, the top branch is taken

KEY IDEA

Yes. Test mode emails test profiles' own inboxes, locks the journey, shortens waits to 10 seconds, and takes the top branch of a split.

Kavya runs the welcome in Test mode

Simulate, then choose Test mode

▼

Send Kavya's Gold seat

▼

Send Rohan's Silver seat

▼

Both take the Gold path

▼

2-day wait passes in 10 seconds

▼

Rohan's email opens: Hi ,

KEY IDEA

Kavya's Gold seat took the Gold path. Rohan's Silver seat took it too, because Test mode takes the top branch, and his email opened with a bare comma.

Dry run: prove every path, contact nobody

Dry run	What to know
Contacts	Nobody: no email, no profile change
Shows	How many real profiles take each path
Counts against	The active journey limit, 100 in dev
Runs for	Up to 14 days
Needs	Publish rights

KEY IDEA

Dry run contacts nobody and shows how many real profiles would take each path. It uses a journey slot, runs up to 14 days and needs publish rights.

Simulation: a real send with no safety rules

- A real send through the normal pipeline
- No suppression, allowed list or consent checks
- No frequency caps, no quiet hours
- 20 simulated users per batch, 100 per run
- No exit criteria, inbound channels, dataset lookups
- Disconnected nodes block it

KEY IDEA

Simulation sends real email to simulated users. Suppression, the allowed list, consent, frequency caps and quiet hours are not applied.

Simulation vs Test mode vs Dry run

Option	Who goes through	Best for
Dry run	Real profiles, counted only	Proving each path
Test mode	Stored test profiles	Email plus top path, fast
Simulation	Made-up simulated users	Quick trial, no ingestion

KEY IDEA

Dry run counts real profiles per path and sends nothing. Test mode emails stored test profiles. Simulation emails made-up users with no protections.

Send proof and Simulate content: the email

- Simulate content: a preview with sample data
- Simulate content (AEP profiles): real test seats
- Switch seats with Test profile name
- Send proof: real email, up to 10 typed addresses
- 5 addresses and 10 test profiles: 50 emails
- Caps apply: a capped seat may get nothing

KEY IDEA

Simulate content previews an email on test profiles and sends nothing. Send proof mails up to 10 typed addresses, multiplied by test profiles, and caps apply.

Why did my email say 'Hi ,'?

- Greeting reads the first name, with no fallback
- Empty first name prints: Hi ,
- Test profiles are complete; real records often aren't
- Keep one deliberately incomplete test profile
- The fix: a fallback for every personalised field

KEY IDEA

Test profiles usually have every field filled; real customers do not. One deliberately incomplete test profile catches a missing-name greeting before go-live.

Bloom's testing plan: cheapest checks first

Your goal	Use
Find errors before anything runs	Alerts panel
Check one email's content	Simulate content, then a proof to you
Email plus path on a test seat	Test mode
Prove how real people split	Dry run
Quick trial, no stored profile	Simulation, own address only

KEY IDEA

Match the option to the question: errors first, then a preview, then Test mode on own seats, then Dry run to prove the split.

Interview corner

- Real inbox: Test mode, Simulation, Send proof
- Never: Dry run and the Alerts panel
- Test mode takes the top branch of a split
- Prove the split with Dry run
- Keep one deliberately incomplete test profile

KEY IDEA

Which test options can reach a real inbox? Test mode, Simulation and Send proof. Dry run never does.

Recap, your question, and the brand team's fear

- Real inbox: Test mode, Simulation, Send proof
- Seats: TD IDs, testProfile true, own inbox
- Test mode takes the top branch; Dry run proves paths
- One incomplete seat catches Hi ,
- Next: one brand voice with fragments

KEY IDEA

Know which buttons send, prove splits with Dry run, keep one incomplete seat. Next: channel configurations, the Email Designer and fragments.